Fibromyalgia

Inclusion Toolkit

Symptoms

- Widespread pain and tenderness lasting three months or more.
- Extreme fatigue that is not relieved by sleep or rest.
- Cognitive issues often called 'fibro-fog' affecting memory and focus.

Age & Gender

- Most common in people aged between 30 and 50, but can affect any age.
- Diagnosed much more frequently in females than in males.

Common myths

- It's a physical condition, not something people imagine.
- It's not a form of arthritis, as it affects soft tissues rather than joints.
- People with fibromyalgia aren't 'just lazy'. The fatigue and pain are often debilitating.

Diagnosis

- There is no specific scan or blood test for Fibromyalgia.
- Diagnosed by a GP or Rheumatologist after checking it isn't another condition.
- Based on widespread pain in specific areas of the body for a long period.

Treatment

- Medication can help manage nerve pain or improve sleep.
- Gentle movement like swimming helps maintain mobility.
- CBT helps manage the mental impact of chronic pain.

How to help

- Be flexible with plans as symptoms can 'flare up' without warning.
- Offer practical help with physical tasks like shopping or cleaning.
- Believe them when they say they are in pain, even if they look well.

This information isn't a diagnostic tool. If you recognise these symptoms in yourself or others, please contact a doctor.